

METI UniPods AI Innovation Programme

Information Pack for Selected Teams

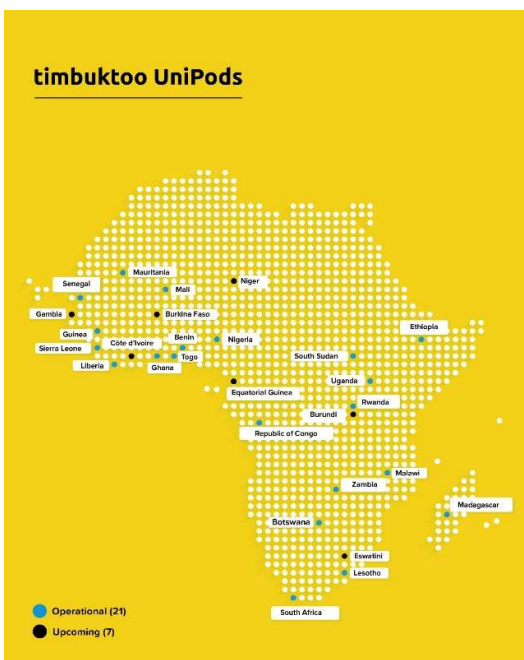
Congratulations on being selected for Cohort 1 of the METI UniPods AI Innovation Programme. This pack sets out what the programme involves, the learning and support on offer, how the different parts connect, and the key dates for the months ahead, so you have a clear picture of what comes next.

About the programme

The METI UniPods AI Programme is an AI skilling and venture building programme funded by the Japanese Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry (METI). Its goal is to give innovators like you the technical skills, entrepreneurial grounding and support you need to advance in AI and turn those skills into ventures.

The programme builds pipeline for the timbuktoo Hubs. timbuktoo is UNDP's initiative to support the startup ecosystem across Africa, offering early-stage capital, policy support and technical support through ten thematic pan-African hubs that run acceleration programmes for startups.

UniPods are makerspaces located in public universities across Africa. They act as a one stop place for innovators to receive technical support from ideation through prototyping, testing and market access. There are currently 23 UniPods across 21 countries, with five more expected by December 2026.



Map of timbuktoo UniPods and Hubs

Your learning offers

The programme brings together several kinds of learning and support to grow both your technical and your entrepreneurial skills. It combines foundational AI learning through MIT, a structured entrepreneurship and innovation curriculum through the Wadhwani Foundation, an advanced AI curriculum through the Addis Ababa AI Institute, and an in-person AI bootcamp in Addis Ababa.

1. MIT: foundational AI

The Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) provides the foundational AI knowledge you will build on throughout the programme. It covers an introduction to AI, Python coding and data analytics, alongside core topics, with exposure to sector applications such as sustainable energy, transportation, medicine and entrepreneurship.

The course is self-paced. It normally costs approximately USD 900, but this is covered for you through a special registration code. You will receive an email with registration instructions, your user code and the fee waiver code. An optional weekly office hour is available if you want live support.

Learn more about the MIT program: <https://learn.mit.edu/universal-learning/ai>

2. Wadhvani Foundation: entrepreneurship and innovation

The Wadhvani Foundation is a global non-profit that runs entrepreneurship and skilling programmes with universities and governments worldwide. Its Ignite programme is a 14-week experiential entrepreneurship journey built by founders, taking participants from idea through to a validated business model, with mentorship, masterclasses and AI-assisted learning support.

Through this partnership you will follow a structured 14-week programme with instructor-led sessions rather than self-paced learning. Twice a week you meet virtually with a Wadhvani instructor on content designed to help you refine your business. Every three weeks there is an in-person meetup at your UniPod for those who can attend, so you can meet your country cohort and build your network.

You will receive a communication from the Wadhvani Foundation and from Charles Bolton, your facilitator and coach for the 14-week journey. It will include:

- Your country-specific cohort details
- Your programme enrolment link and cohort code
- Step-by-step platform onboarding instructions
- A short how-to guide video to assist with enrolment
- An invitation and Microsoft Teams link for the live online welcome session

The programme is introduced at the live online welcome session on Thursday, 10 September 2026 at 3:00 PM CAT, 4:00 PM EAT and 2:00 PM WAT.

The 14-week journey then begins on Tuesday, 15 September 2026, with two live Teams sessions each week:

- Tuesdays, live class session: the weekly Ignite content, activities and business model development journey
- Thursdays, live Q and A and coaching session: questions, practical application, venture development and coaching support

You will also work through the relevant Ignite platform content and activities between sessions.

Learn more about Wadhvani: <https://wadhanifoundation.org/our-programs/ignite/>

3. Ethiopian AI Institute: intermediate to advanced AI

The programme is anchored in the Ethiopian AI Institute, where the Ethiopia AI UniPod is situated. The Institute supports the programme in two ways: an instructor-facilitated three-month virtual programme covering intermediate to advanced AI, and an in-person bootcamp hosted in Addis Ababa.

The online programme builds directly on what you learned through MIT and is supported by assignments and structured coursework, with sessions led by instructors rather than self-paced. Selected participants from this stage join the Institute's in-person bootcamp.

Learn more about the EAI: <https://aii.et/>

How it all connects

Cohort 1 starts with 250 solutions, some individual and some team-based. Each solution is required to register one person for the MIT course. Although the course is self-paced, we expect it to be completed within a month.

The 14-week Wadhwani programme runs concurrently, and each team should have at least one person signed up. Wadhwani has no signup limit, so you may enrol as many people from your team as you wish. At least one of them must complete the programme.

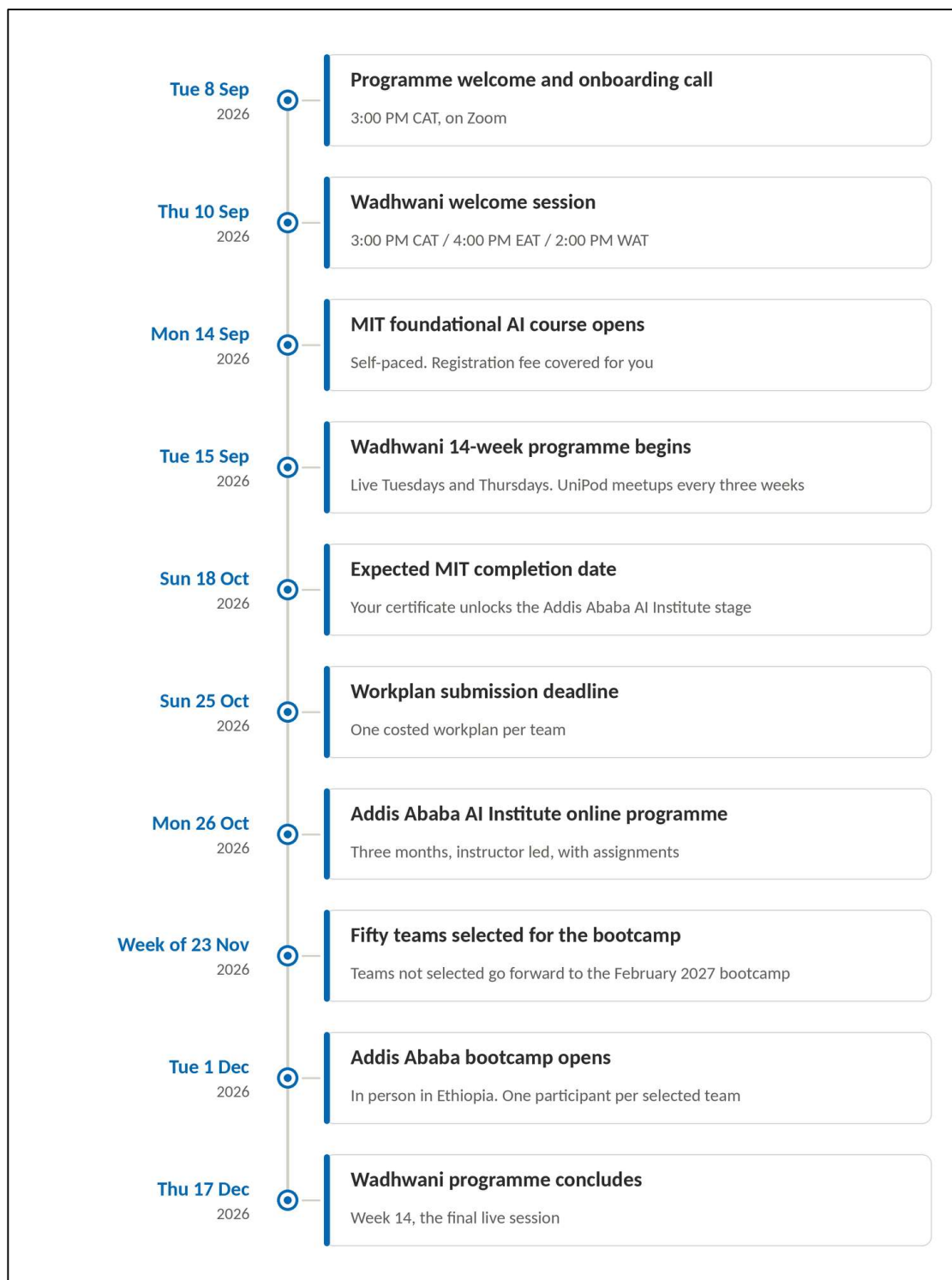
Teams that complete MIT and are on track with Wadhwani proceed to the Ethiopian AI Institute phase and are supported to develop workplans for tailored support.

In the last week of November the Institute selects the 50 strongest solutions to attend the bootcamp in Ethiopia. Each selected team sends one person. Solutions not selected are considered for the second bootcamp in February 2027.

The top teams coming out of the bootcamp receive further support from the programme and transition into the timbuktoo Hubs programmes.

Programme timeline

Anything that changes will be communicated through the WhatsApp group and email



Joining the welcome call

The programme welcome and onboarding call takes place on Tuesday, 8 September 2026 at 3:00 PM CAT. Please join using these Teams details:

<https://teams.microsoft.com/meet/360293151621628?p=cM5gEphg2N9i9d0w7G>

Meeting ID: 360 293 151 621 628

Passcode: C9zH7Nr3

Questions

If you have questions, please ask in the WhatsApp group or email unipods.regional@undp.org. We would rather answer the same question ten times than have you stuck.